television interviews. It was almost as if he now felt ‘liberated’ from the self-imposed cage in which he had locked himself over the last five years.

The media blitz was well choreographed. Modi would do his interviews almost in tune with the election calendar. So, for example, he did an interview with the news agency ANI just a day before the crucial phase five of the elections. Campaigning had ended in 121 seats in twelve states, but Modi knew the interview would be carried across all the channels which subscribed to the agency just ahead of the polling. When Tamil Nadu was going to the polls, he spoke to Tamil channels; when Bengal was going to elections, the preference was for regional Bengali channels; and when his home state of Gujarat was polling, Gujarati news channels were targeted. ‘Narendrabhai knew the power of regional networks and actually told us he would prefer speaking to them,’ is how a Team Modi member put it to me.

His energy was boundless. He would do the interviews at his Gandhinagar residence either before he set off on the campaign trail at 9 a.m. or after he had returned well past 10 p.m. Modi had always loved the camera; now he wanted to make up, it appears, for the lost years, when he had consciously stayed away from it.

The scheduling of the interviews was left to a small group of officials, mainly from the Gujarat government. Modi didn’t have, contrary to popular belief, a highly qualified team of external professional media advisers. His PRO, Jagdish Thakkar, for example, was from the state information department and had been with the Gujarat chief minister’s office since 1989 (he would later move with Modi to the PMO). Whenever I’d phone Jagdishbhai seeking time for an interview, he’d talk to me about my father’s batting instead. ‘Oh, what a batsman Dilip Sardesai was!’ he’d say, fobbing me off. I told him that much as I liked hearing praise of my father’s cricketing skills, I’d feel even better once I had got my Modi interview.

I did not get the interview, though Modi had promised me one and had even said no questions were taboo (‘*Arre, tumse koi dushmani nahi, Rajdeep*’—I have no enmity with you), but at least my network did get more than one. The only major news network that wasn’t given an interview was NDTV. Modi, it seems, still hadn’t forgiven or forgotten the